

Value Structure

Organizing values for clarity and impact

Value structure means organizing all the values in your drawing into a clear, coherent hierarchy. Without value structure, even technically correct drawings feel muddy, weak, or visually confusing.

KEY CONCEPTS

Value Scale

A value scale runs from absolute white (1) to absolute black (10). Most drawings use 5–7 distinct values. Fewer values = stronger, bolder design. More values = more nuance and realism. For studies, start with 3 values only: white, mid-grey, black.

Value Contrast

The eye is drawn to areas of highest contrast. Use your darkest dark next to your lightest light at the focal point. Push contrast at the center of interest; reduce it at the periphery.

Big Shapes First

Establish large value shapes before small ones. The overall light/dark pattern should read clearly from across the room before you add any local value variation. If the big shapes don't work, the small ones won't save the drawing.

Limited Value Range

Forcing yourself to work with only 3–4 values is one of the best exercises in value design. It forces every mark to serve a structural purpose. Once you can make 3 values sing, expand to 5, then 7.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Do a 3-value study of any subject (white, grey, black only). Strict limit.
 2. Copy a master drawing using only 5 values. Mix to get exact matches.
 3. Do 10 thumbnail value sketches of different lighting scenarios (2 min each).
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FURTHER READING

■ Ctrl+Paint – Value

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/value-scales>

■ Proko – Value in Drawing

<https://youtu.be/V3WmrWUElJo>